◆ DESIGN SYSTEM & EXPERIENCE

KINETIC TYPE

UI / UX Brief

A biomechanical instrument, not a toy. The visual language of precision timing — dark, calibrated, alive under the fingers.

INSTRUMENT AESTHETIC · MOTION-FIRST FEEDBACK · DARK PRIMARY

VERSION	STATUS	DATE	DISCIPLINE
1.0	Draft for Review	31 Aug 2026	Product Design

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01 Design Philosophy

Every typing product on the market is skinned like a toy — playful fonts, confetti, leaderboard gamification. Kinetic Type is skinned like an **instrument**: the aesthetic of an oscilloscope, a recording studio, a biometric lab. The interface should feel like it is *measuring* you, precisely and without judgment, and handing the data back with total clarity.

PRINCIPLE 01

Precision reads as premium

Monospace numerals, exact millisecond values, hairline grids. Nothing rounded to "good enough" — the product's credibility is the credibility of the numbers it shows.

PRINCIPLE 02

The stage disappears, the signal remains

Chrome recedes to near-black. The only saturated color on screen at any time is the one carrying information — a weak key-pair, a live stat, a trend line.

PRINCIPLE 03

Motion is feedback, not decoration

Every animation answers a question the user just asked with their fingers — "did that register," "was that a miss," "am I improving." Nothing moves without a reason.

PRINCIPLE 04

Calm under speed

Even at 120WPM the interface stays legible and unhurried — dense information, unhurried presentation. Confidence, not chaos.

ONE-LINE BRIEF

"A dark instrument panel that turns your own hands into the interface."

02 Aesthetic Direction

The visual world sits at the intersection of three references, none copied wholesale: the readout density of a **recording studio mixing console**, the hairline precision of a **surgical/biometric instrument**, and the glow of a **terminal at 2am**.

REFERENCE A

Studio Console

Dense stat readouts, VU-meter style bars, tactile chip-shaped controls with subtle bevels.

REFERENCE B

Biometric Instrument

Waveform lines, EKG-style latency traces, clinical restraint in color — signal color only where it means something.

REFERENCE C

Late-Night Terminal

Monospace type, cursor blink, syntax-highlight color logic borrowed for state (teal=good, amber=friction).

SURFACE LANGUAGE

- **Base:** near-black ink (`#0B0F19`) — never pure black, holds a cool navy undertone.
- **Elevation:** panels lift with subtle lightness steps (+1 tone) and a 1px hairline border, never a heavy drop shadow — flat, layered, precise.
- **Grid:** a faint 8mm dot/line grid ghosted at 3–4% opacity on hero surfaces, reinforcing the "instrument panel" feel without competing with content.
- **Focus mode (light):** an optional high-key alternate theme for daylight/low-glare use — same structure, inverted values, same accent hues at adjusted saturation for contrast compliance.

WHAT TO AVOID

No confetti, no cartoon mascots, no drop-shadowed skeuomorphic keycaps, no gradient buttons. If an element wouldn't look at home on a piece of lab equipment, it doesn't belong.

03 Color System

One neutral spine, one dominant signal color, three narrow-use semantic accents. Saturated color is a scarce resource — it always means something.

Ink
#0B0F19
App background

Panel
#141824
Cards, surfaces

Signal Teal
#4FD1C5
Correct / live / primary

Structure Blue
#6D8BFF
Cursor / system / links

Friction Amber
#FF8A5C
Weak key-pair / error

Engine Violet
#C792EA
Adaptive engine accent

Cream
#E9ECF5
Primary text on dark

Faint
#8A91A6
Secondary / meta text

Hairline
#262C3D
Borders, dividers

SEMANTIC MAPPING

STATE	COLOR	WHERE IT APPEARS
Correctly typed character	TEAL	Text stream trail
Active cursor position	BLUE	Typing stage caret block
Targeted weak key-pair	AMBER	Upcoming text highlight, heatmap "hot" keys
Adaptive engine activity	VIOLET	"Synthesizer" badges, engine-related UI

All text/background pairs meet WCAG 2.1 AA (4.5:1) at minimum; heatmap ramp uses a colorblind-safe teal→amber scale, never red→green.

04 Typography System

DISPLAY & UI

Poppins

Geometric, confident, slightly rounded — used for headings, navigation, and buttons. Never used for numbers.

DATA & TYPE STREAM

Mono

Every number, timestamp, key-pair label, and the typing stage itself is monospace — tabular alignment is non-negotiable for a product about timing.

TYPE SCALE

Kinetic Type

Display / 30·700 / Poppins

Session Complete

H1 / 20·600 / Poppins

Latency by Key-Pair

H2 / 15·600 / Poppins

104 WPM

Stat / 22·700 / Mono

Body copy for descriptions and settings labels.

Body / 11·400 / DejaVu Sans

e→r 12.4ms

Type Stream / 16 / Mono

EYEBROW LABEL

Label / 9·mono / 0.12em tracking

05 Motif & Iconography

Two recurring visual motifs tie every screen back to the product's core mechanic: the **keycap chip** and the **latency waveform**.

KEYCAP CHIP

Any reference to a specific key or key-pair — in tables, tooltips, or the results screen — renders as a small physical-feeling chip: monospace label, 1px border, subtle bottom-edge shadow suggesting key travel.

`e` `→` `r`   `Shift` `→` `{`   `sudo` `␣`

LATENCY WAVEFORM

An EKG-style polyline used as a decorative and functional motif — on covers, as a loading state, and literally as the per-pair latency trend sparkline in analytics.

ICONOGRAPHY RULES

- Line icons only, 1.5px stroke, no fills — consistent with the "instrument," not "app icon," feel.
- Domain modes get a single glyph each: `</>` Dev, `$_` CLI, `¶` Prose.
- No emoji anywhere in the core product UI.

06 Screen — Onboarding & Domain Select

First-session friction must be near-zero: no account, no settings — pick a domain, start typing, see the diagnosis appear.

kinetictype.app

◆ CHOOSE YOUR DOMAIN

What does your keyboard usually do?

</>
Dev Mode
Code syntax, brackets, camelCase

$_
CLI Mode
Shell flags, paths, regex

¶
Prose Mode
Literature & transcription

No account needed — your baseline calibrates in the first 30 seconds.

BEHAVIOR NOTES

- Domain selection persists locally as the default for next visit but is always one tap away from changing.
- Selecting a card previews 2–3 lines of that domain's actual text style before committing.
- "Calibration" is just the first ~30 seconds of normal typing — never framed as a separate test.

07 Screen — The Typing Stage

The core screen. Everything not essential to the current keystroke is dimmed or removed — a live stat rail sits above a single, generously-spaced text stream.

kinetictype.app/session

</> DEV · $_ CLI · ¶ PROSE

97	98.2%	00:24	Shift→{
WPM NET	ACCURACY	ELAPSED	TARGETED PAIR

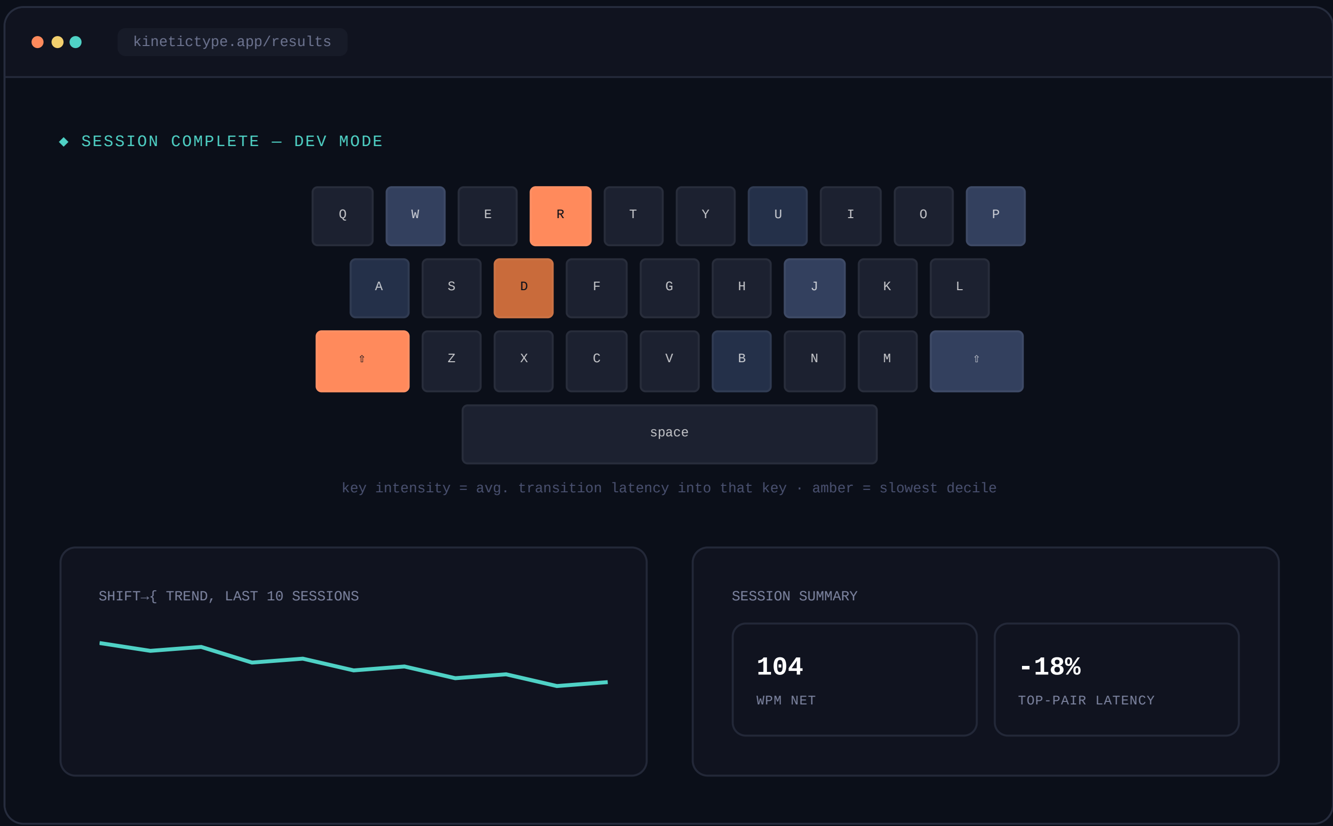
```
const handleSubmit = (event) => { event.preventDefault();
  setLoading(true);
};
```

teal = correct · blue = cursor · amber = adaptive-engine target now entering the stream

BEHAVIOR NOTES

- No native text cursor, no input box border — the block caret *is* the only interactive chrome on the stage.
- An incorrect keystroke never blocks progress; it marks the character and the engine logs it, matching real-world typing (no "stop and fix").
- The next-chunk of text streams in seamlessly from the right; there is no page/paragraph break to interrupt rhythm.

08 Screen — Results & Latency Heatmap



09 Motion & Micro-interactions

Motion exists to answer a felt question the instant it's asked. Every interaction below is under 220ms — fast enough to read as feedback, never as animation.

INTERACTION	MOTION	TIMING / CURVE
Correct keystroke	Character crossfades from upcoming-grey to teal; 1px underline sweeps in	120ms · ease-out
Incorrect keystroke	Character flashes amber, 2px horizontal shake (±1.5px)	160ms · ease-in-out
Cursor advance	Block caret slides to next glyph position, no fade	80ms · linear
New chunk streamed in	Upcoming text fades up from 0 → 60% opacity from the right edge	200ms · ease-out
Session-end transition	Stage dims to 20%, results panel rises from bottom 12px + fade	220ms · cubic-bezier(.2,.8,.2,1)
Heatmap key "hot" pulse	Subtle 4% scale breathing loop while a key remains in the active weak-pair pool	1.8s loop · ease-in-out
Streak / milestone	Single teal glow ring expands once from the stat and fades — never confetti	300ms · ease-out

REDUCED MOTION

Every effect above degrades to a pure color/opacity change with no movement when `prefers-reduced-motion` is set — timing values stay, translation/scale is stripped.

10 Component Library

BUTTONS

Start Session

View History

Cancel

CHIPS & TAGS

CORRECT

WEAK PAIR

SYSTEM

ADAPTIVE

NEUTRAL

STAT TILES

104	98.2%	3	D7
WPM NET	ACCURACY	WEAK PAIRS FOUND	STREAK

DOMAIN TABS

</> DEV

$_ CLI

¶ PROSE

11 Accessibility & Modes

REQUIREMENT	IMPLEMENTATION
Color contrast	All text/background combinations verified ≥ 4.5:1 (body) / 3:1 (large text) per WCAG 2.1 AA.
Colorblind-safe heatmap	Teal → amber luminance-separated ramp, never relying on hue alone; intensity also encoded via saturation.
Reduced motion	All translate/scale animation strips to opacity/color-only transitions under `prefers-reduced-motion`.
Keyboard operability	Every non-typing control (menus, settings, domain switch) fully operable via Tab/Enter — typing itself is the primary input, chrome must never require a mouse.
Focus indication	2px teal focus ring, always visible, never suppressed via `outline:none`.
Light "Focus Mode"	Alternate high-key theme (paper background, deep-ink text) for daylight and low-glare preference — identical structure, inverted values.

End of UI/UX Brief — Kinetic Type v1.0. Confidential & Proprietary.